



North Africa Regional Policy Dialogue on Adaptation Accountability and the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA). Report

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1.0 Executive Summary

The North Africa dialogue brought together policymakers, practitioners, civil society representatives, and technical experts to examine how regional adaptation governance and global accountability frameworks can better reflect local realities in Egypt. Discussions focused on three interconnected themes: accountability in adaptation systems; the relevance and feasibility of Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA) indicators and measurement; and the role of evidence, transparency, and feedback mechanisms. Participants highlighted the need to strengthen community engagement and representation, improve the accessibility and transparency of adaptation-related data, and establish clearer mechanisms for feedback and accountability. Regarding the GGA, participants recognised the relevance of its thematic priorities to Egypt but raised concerns about the capacity, data infrastructure, reporting requirements, and institutional coordination needed to implement indicators effectively, emphasising the importance of contextualising global frameworks without creating additional burdens for national institutions.

2.0 Dialogue Overview

2.1 Background

The Africa Research and Impact Network (ARIN) collaborated with the University College London (UCL) to administer a Mini-Grant Programme aimed at exploring novel accountability mechanisms for climate change adaptation in Africa in 2024. The programme attracted seven early-career researchers (ECRs) working in African contexts and they successfully generated empirically grounded research that interrogates how accountability operates in adaptation planning, financing, and implementation across different governance levels. However, there remained a significant gap in structured policy engagement capable of translating these insights into ongoing regional and global policy processes.

This gap is particularly salient in the context of the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA), where questions of measurement, indicators, and accountability remain contested. African stakeholders continue to face challenges in ensuring that adaptation metrics, financing frameworks, and reporting systems meaningfully reflect on-the-ground realities and support accountable, locally responsive adaptation action.

2.2 Participants

The North Africa dialogue was held in Cairo, Egypt, on 20 August 2026. The dialogue was initially planned for 25 participants from diverse backgrounds and with a range of professional experiences. On the day of the event, 9 participants attended, including representatives from the National Research Centre for Agriculture, civil society organisations working on climate adaptation and awareness in Egypt, technical experts working at the intersection of financial landscapes and built-environment projects, environmental consultants, and representatives working with international organisations and donors.

The participants brought diverse perspectives and experiences in engaging with government institutions and international donors on climate adaptation projects and climate readiness plans. They also had varied experience working directly with communities, providing perspectives on climate adaptation from institutional, technical, financial, civil society, and community-oriented contexts.

2.3 Format

The dialogue was convened in a hybrid format, with eight participants attending in person alongside the ARIN team, while one additional expert from Egypt joined remotely via Zoom.

3.0 Key Discussion Themes

3.1 How Accountability is Understood and Operationalised:

Guiding questions: How do stakeholders in the region define accountability for climate adaptation? Where does the emphasis lie? Is the primary focus on upward accountability (to funders and government), downward accountability (to local communities), or horizontal accountability (among institutions and actors)?

During the first part of the session, participants discussed how accountability is understood and practised in the context of climate adaptation. Accountability was not described as a term or practice that is widely used or explicitly considered within work environments. The initial discussion focused on the Arabic translation of the term and whether it is commonly used in professional contexts. Participants generally understood accountability as an upward process, primarily directed towards international funders or government institutions. By contrast, downward and

horizontal forms of accountability were perceived as limited, largely because communities are often absent from climate adaptation processes.

Participants noted that communities are rarely involved in the negotiation and design of large-scale climate projects, plans, or international agreements. As a result, these processes can remain distant from communities until their impacts become directly relevant to everyday life. Limited transparency and access to information and data further restrict communities' ability to understand adaptation processes and question the decisions and actions of relevant actors. Participants also highlighted the absence of appropriate assessment frameworks as a barrier to accountability. A locally relevant framework for assessing adaptation plans, projects, and practices was considered necessary for accountability to become more meaningful and operational.

Institutional complexity was identified as an additional barrier. The involvement of multiple institutions, departments, and hierarchical levels can make it difficult for individuals and communities to identify the appropriate entity to approach with questions or concerns. Participants also highlighted limited awareness of national and international climate policies and of the role of civil society organisations (CSOs), particularly as barriers to horizontal accountability between communities and civil society actors. More broadly, participants noted that existing systems provide limited channels through which communities can question decisions or hold actors accountable.

A further perspective concerned the language used to communicate environmental and climate issues. Participants suggested that reframing these issues in language that relates more closely to people's everyday experiences could help reduce the gap between formal climate discourse and local realities. This could enable communities to engage more meaningfully with climate-related policies, projects, and agreements and strengthen their ability to question and hold relevant actors accountable.

Synthesis of perspectives: What are the dominant narratives? What are the key points of convergence or disagreement among different stakeholder types (e.g., government vs. civil society)?

There was some divergence among participants regarding the extent to which communities are aware of and interested in environmental and climate issues. While several participants emphasised limited community awareness, others suggested that the issue is less about a lack of awareness than about how interest is expressed and translated into action. Communities may be aware of climate and environmental issues when these directly affect their daily lives, particularly their economic circumstances. However, participants noted that translating this awareness into questioning decisions or holding other actors accountable is not common practice

and can be constrained by time, economic pressures, and the complexity of navigating institutional systems.

A dominant theme was the complexity of the institutional and procedural channels through which accountability could be exercised, combined with limited access to information and data. Participants also highlighted a disconnect between the technical and institutional language used to discuss climate change and the language used in everyday community contexts. Although both may address similar issues, the formal framing of climate concerns can distance communities from climate discourse and limit their engagement.

Institutional fragmentation was identified as a related challenge. Climate issues often cut across institutional mandates and disciplinary boundaries, while responsibilities remain distributed across different departments and institutions. This makes it difficult to identify who is responsible for a particular issue or where concerns should be directed. Participants noted that addressing complex climate challenges requires greater collaboration across institutional and disciplinary boundaries.

Key challenges: What are the main barriers to operationalising accountability in this region (e.g., weak institutional coordination, lack of access to information, power imbalances)?

The dominance of upward accountability, particularly towards international funders, was identified as a significant challenge. Participants noted that organisations may prioritise donor-defined objectives and thematic priorities, which do not always correspond directly to the most pressing challenges experienced by local communities. One example discussed was an African network that provides climate funding while allowing applicants to identify the issues they consider most relevant to their local contexts. Participants viewed this approach as supporting more locally grounded and potentially more context-responsive interventions, rather than projects shaped primarily by predefined donor priorities.

Participants also emphasised that communities are more likely to engage in accountability processes when climate projects address issues directly connected to their lived realities. Where interventions have a clear and tangible relationship to local environments and everyday concerns, communities may be better positioned to raise questions and influence decisions. Conversely, participants noted that individuals representing communities in international forums, such as COP or the World Urban Forum, may not always reflect the experiences or priorities of the communities they represent. This can contribute to gaps between formal representation and local perspectives.

Finally, participants highlighted the importance of the wider social and political context in shaping accountability. The availability, transparency, and accessibility of information were considered particularly important. Participants noted that higher-level institutions and stakeholders need to make relevant information accessible to communities if communities are to meaningfully engage in accountability processes. At present, this was perceived as a significant gap.

3.2 Relevance and Feasibility of GGA Indicators:

Guiding questions: Which of the proposed GGA indicator themes (e.g., water scarcity, food security, infrastructure resilience) are most relevant to the region? Which are most challenging to implement or potentially misaligned with local realities?

Participants noted strong alignment between the proposed GGA indicator themes and Egypt's existing national climate planning priorities. Water scarcity, livelihoods, and agriculture were identified as particularly relevant themes for the Egyptian context. This alignment was viewed positively, as it could provide opportunities to build on existing national priorities and reporting structures rather than establishing entirely new thematic areas.

Practical constraints: What are the specific, practical barriers to implementing these indicators?

Data collection capacity was identified as a major challenge, including the availability of appropriate data-collection mechanisms and skilled personnel to collect, manage, and report data. Participants noted that reductions in government staffing may further constrain institutional capacity, particularly where experienced personnel are lost. Limited financing for data collection was identified as an additional constraint.

The centralisation of data collection and reporting was also considered a challenge for aggregating information across sectors. While some specialised ministries have local offices with access to local-level data, this capacity varies across sectors. Participants also noted that the frequency of data collection required by the indicators could create additional administrative and financial burdens, particularly where existing data systems do not align with GGA requirements.

A related concern was the use of predefined indicators that may not adequately reflect local priorities or conditions. Collecting data primarily to satisfy externally defined indicators could generate information of limited relevance to local adaptation planning while increasing reporting demands. Participants therefore emphasised the importance of allowing flexibility to incorporate context-specific data and priorities.

Participants further highlighted the limited integration of communities into formal government data collection and reporting systems. Direct community monitoring was considered difficult to operationalise within the existing centralised system. Local government offices, whose personnel are embedded within communities, were identified as a potential intermediary for capturing locally relevant information while maintaining links with formal reporting structures. Participants also noted that some routinely collected government statistics do not directly correspond to the proposed GGA indicators, creating an additional gap between existing data systems and GGA reporting requirements.

To address these constraints, participants proposed a designated GGA coordination function within the responsible ministry to coordinate reporting, support training and capacity building, and consolidate data from different institutions. A shared digital reporting system was also suggested to facilitate data submission and aggregation across sectors, reduce duplication, and strengthen coordination. Together, these measures could help align GGA reporting with existing institutional capacities and data systems while reducing additional reporting burdens.

3.3 Evidence, Transparency, and Feedback Mechanisms:

Guiding Questions: What types of evidence do stakeholders trust most for tracking adaptation progress? (e.g., scientific data, community-based monitoring, indigenous knowledge)?

Participants predominantly identified quantitative data as the most trusted form of evidence for tracking adaptation progress. They noted that qualitative information may also be useful but is often expected to be translated into measurable indicators or trends to support formal reporting. Participants described a data system in which information is generally collected through local government offices and subsequently aggregated for national reporting. Consultants may also be engaged to undertake data collection. However, some participants questioned the reliability of externally collected data, particularly when consultants have limited familiarity with the local context. This was considered particularly relevant in rural and remote areas, where contextual knowledge may be important for interpreting local conditions and ensuring that collected data accurately reflects realities on the ground.

Participants also emphasised the need to distinguish between data collection and data reporting. While these processes are closely connected, they involve different responsibilities and should be considered separately when assessing transparency and accountability. Understanding who collects the data, how it is collected, who verifies it, and who is responsible for reporting it was identified as important for strengthening confidence in adaptation evidence.

Useful transparency: What information would be most useful to share, and with whom, to strengthen accountability without creating a burdensome reporting exercise?

Participants highlighted the potential to make greater use of existing local government offices that are distributed across the country. These offices could provide an established institutional infrastructure for collecting, accessing, and communicating locally relevant information, while reducing the need to create entirely new reporting mechanisms. The discussion also highlighted the importance of ensuring that information shared for accountability purposes is accessible and relevant to the stakeholders who need to use it, without creating additional and unnecessary reporting burdens.

Closing the loop: What mechanisms currently exist (or are needed) for communities to give feedback on adaptation projects? How can GGA reporting be linked to these local feedback loops?

Participants indicated that there is currently no formal or consistent feedback mechanism through which communities can systematically respond to climate adaptation projects. Instead, feedback and assessment are generally undertaken on a project-by-project basis and vary according to the stakeholders involved. This represents a significant gap in linking adaptation implementation with community perspectives and experiences.

4.0 Spotlight on Fellow's Research

Cairo, the capital of Egypt and the centre of the country's economic, social, and cultural activities, is one of the largest and most densely populated metropolitan areas in the world. Greater Cairo is particularly exposed to climate-related challenges, including extreme heat, air pollution, and the impacts of rapid urbanisation and uneven population distribution. These challenges are compounded by complex governance conditions and limited levels of community participation in climate action. Within this context, civil society organisations (CSOs) play an important intermediary role, connecting communities with government institutions and international donors and contributing to climate adaptation, awareness, and capacity-building efforts.

The research examines the role of civil society in climate adaptation governance in Cairo, with a particular focus on social learning and horizontal accountability between CSOs and communities. Using an interpretative qualitative approach, the research draws primarily on interviews with civil society actors to explore their role in

knowledge co-production, their relationships with communities, and the ways in which communication, participation, and feedback are established. The study highlights a gap between the growing emphasis on participation in climate governance and the limited attention given to the accountability of CSOs towards the communities they engage with. Rather than being understood as mutual processes of learning and knowledge co-production, relationships between CSOs and communities can remain shaped by hierarchical models in which organisations act primarily as knowledge providers or capacity builders.

The findings indicate that horizontal accountability in Cairo's climate adaptation landscape remains limited and is influenced by power asymmetries, donor priorities, government agendas, short-term project cycles, and restricted forms of community participation. While CSOs demonstrate strong commitment to public engagement and capacity building, accountability is often directed upwards towards donors and government institutions rather than horizontally towards communities, and community engagement can remain ad hoc rather than institutionalised. The paper argues that social learning can provide a pathway towards more meaningful accountability and climate adaptation by strengthening community voice, improving access to knowledge, enabling iterative engagement, and supporting more balanced relationships between actors. It therefore calls for a shift from output-focused and project-based approaches towards approaches that recognise learning, knowledge circulation, active community participation, and networked practices as central to strengthening adaptive capacity and enabling longer-term systemic change.

Implications on the broader policy discussions

The empirical findings from the research broadly aligned with the discussions on accountability during the Cairo dialogue. CSO representatives recognised the challenges identified in the research, particularly those concerning the relationships between CSOs and communities. Participants emphasised that the timeframe of grant-funded projects is an important factor in enabling meaningful and sustained engagement, allowing communities sufficient time to understand, contribute to, and influence decisions.

The discussion also highlighted that CSOs are not generally required to establish formal mechanisms of horizontal accountability towards communities. Nevertheless, participants noted that many CSOs seek to strengthen their relationships with communities as part of their organisational values and social role. This reflects an important distinction between accountability as a formal requirement and accountability as a practice embedded in relationships and ways of working.

Participants further noted that the term *accountability* itself is not widely used in professional practice. Creating opportunities to discuss what accountability means, how it is practised, and towards whom it is directed was therefore identified as an important step towards strengthening accountability in climate adaptation. In this context, the research perspective on social learning offers a useful way of understanding how accountability can be strengthened through sustained interaction, knowledge exchange, and feedback between communities and other adaptation actors.

The dialogue also extended the research discussion by highlighting the institutional and policy conditions that shape the potential for social learning and accountability in practice. Strengthening accountable adaptation requires more than improved indicators, reporting systems, or formal accountability mechanisms. It also requires conditions that enable different actors to exchange knowledge, recognise locally grounded experience, engage communities in interpreting adaptation challenges, and use feedback to inform subsequent decisions. Social learning can therefore provide a pathway towards locally responsive adaptation governance, connecting processes of knowledge production and exchange with broader accountability processes.

5. Region-Specific Implications and Recommendations

5.1 For Regional Adaptation Governance: What are the key implications for actors within this specific region (e.g., for a Regional Economic Community, for national governments in the region)?

The dialogue highlighted several implications for strengthening accountability and participation within regional adaptation governance.

First, identifying clear institutional entry points and connection channels is important for enabling communities to communicate concerns, provide feedback, and engage with relevant stakeholders and government institutions. Clear pathways for communication and feedback can help address the institutional fragmentation that currently makes it difficult for communities to identify where and how to raise concerns.

Second, improving the availability, transparency, and accessibility of climate-related data is essential for enabling meaningful accountability. Information needs to be communicated in accessible language and through channels that communities can realistically use. This requires not only making data publicly available but also

considering how information is presented and communicated so that communities can understand its relevance to their everyday lives.

Third, participants highlighted the need for locally relevant assessment frameworks for adaptation efforts. Such frameworks could provide a basis for assessing adaptation plans and projects against clearly defined local objectives, indicators, and available evidence. This would enable stakeholders and communities to better understand progress and compare reported achievements with locally observable outcomes, thereby providing a stronger basis for accountability.

Finally, participants emphasised the importance of reframing climate issues in language that is grounded in everyday experiences and local concerns. Rather than treating climate adaptation as a specialised, high-level policy issue, communication should connect adaptation to issues that directly affect people's daily lives and livelihoods. This could help make climate action more accessible and relevant to communities and create stronger foundations for engagement and accountability.

5.2 For the GGA Process: Based on this region's discussion, what specific message should be taken to the global stage regarding the development and implementation of the GGA indicators?

Participants emphasised that the implementation of GGA indicators should be accompanied by adequate capacity building for the personnel responsible for data collection, management, and reporting. Strengthening institutional capacity will be important to ensure that reporting requirements can be integrated into existing systems without creating unsustainable additional demands on government institutions.

The use of technology was also identified as an opportunity to support data aggregation, storage, and reporting. A shared digital system could enable relevant institutions to upload and consolidate data through a common platform and facilitate the transfer of information to the designated unit responsible for GGA reporting.

Participants further emphasised the need for sufficient flexibility within the GGA framework to allow indicators and data requirements to be adapted to different national and local contexts. While common indicators can support comparability, overly prescriptive requirements may generate data that are difficult to collect or have limited relevance to local adaptation priorities. The GGA process should therefore balance the need for consistency and comparability with sufficient scope for contextualisation.

Overall, participants expressed concern that the current reporting requirements could place substantial additional demands on national institutions if they are not aligned with existing data systems, capacities, and reporting processes. Ensuring that the GGA framework is feasible within different institutional and resource contexts was therefore identified as an important consideration for its implementation.

5.3 Emerging Priorities: What are 2-3 priority actions or focus areas identified by stakeholders for strengthening accountable adaptation in this region?

The dialogue highlighted three interconnected priorities for strengthening accountable adaptation: making climate adaptation more accessible and locally relevant; improving access to adaptation-related evidence; and ensuring that locally grounded knowledge and experience inform adaptation decision-making.

1. Reframe climate adaptation in accessible and locally relevant language.

Participants emphasised the need to communicate climate adaptation through language and concepts that relate to everyday experiences and local concerns. Reframing climate discourse in more accessible and contextually relevant terms could help reduce the gap between formal policy discussions and community realities and create stronger opportunities for meaningful engagement.

2. Strengthen data transparency and accessibility.

Improving the availability, transparency, and accessibility of adaptation-related data was identified as an important foundation for accountability. Stakeholders need access to relevant information in forms that enable them to understand adaptation priorities, follow progress, and engage meaningfully with decision-making processes.

3. Ensure locally grounded knowledge is represented in adaptation discussions.

Participants highlighted the importance of ensuring that people directly experiencing climate impacts are represented in adaptation discussions and decision-making processes. Farmers, for example, are already undertaking adaptation measures in response to changing conditions, yet their experiences and knowledge may not be adequately reflected in formal adaptation processes. Creating mechanisms to incorporate such knowledge could help ensure that adaptation planning, assessment, and reporting reflect locally grounded practices and priorities, while providing a stronger basis for dialogue, feedback, and accountability.

